

Senior Cat Litter Box Refusal — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

GET PROPER MEDICAL TESTING DONE

- ☐ **Call your vet and request a senior wellness workup focused specifically on pain assessment and cognitive function, not a standard wellness exam, because standard exams routinely miss the conditions that cause senior litter box refusal.:** Call your vet and request a senior wellness workup focused specifically on pain assessment and cognitive function, not a standard wellness exam, because standard exams routinely miss the conditions that cause senior litter box refusal.
- ☐ **Ask the vet to X-ray your cat's spine and hind limbs specifically to screen for arthritis, since degenerative joint disease affects 60-90% of cats over 12 and causes pain that makes your cat avoid the box.:** Ask the vet to X-ray your cat's spine and hind limbs specifically to screen for arthritis, since degenerative joint disease affects 60-90% of cats over 12 and causes pain that makes your cat avoid the box.
- ☐ **Request comprehensive blood work and urinalysis to rule out hyperthyroidism, kidney disease, and diabetes, all common in cats over 8 that can cause increased urination, urgency, and litter box aversion.:** Request comprehensive blood work and urinalysis to rule out hyperthyroidism, kidney disease, and diabetes, all common in cats over 8 that can cause increased urination, urgency, and litter box aversion.
- ☐ **Bring up cognitive dysfunction syndrome directly with your vet by asking about disorientation, sleep cycle changes, and unusual elimination patterns, since vets often don't volunteer this information even when it applies.:** Bring up cognitive dysfunction syndrome directly with your vet by asking about disorientation, sleep cycle changes, and unusual elimination patterns, since vets often don't volunteer this information even when it applies.

MODIFY THE LITTER BOX SETUP

- ☐ **Replace any litter box with a rim lip higher than 2 inches with a low-entry design or storage bin with a cut-out entrance, because high sides require painful climbing that your arthritic senior cat learns to avoid.:** Replace any litter box with a rim lip higher than 2 inches with a low-entry design or storage bin with a cut-out entrance, because high sides require painful climbing that your arthritic senior cat learns to avoid.
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- ❑ **Measure your cat from nose to tail base and buy or modify a box that is at least 1.5 times that length, because cramped boxes that don't allow comfortable turning are a major avoidance trigger.:** Measure your cat from nose to tail base and buy or modify a box that is at least 1.5 times that length, because cramped boxes that don't allow comfortable turning are a major avoidance trigger.

- ❑ **Switch to fine-grain clumping litter at approximately 1 inch depth instead of coarse or dusty litter, because rough litter textures aggravate sensitive paws and arthritic discomfort in senior cats.:** Switch to fine-grain clumping litter at approximately 1 inch depth instead of coarse or dusty litter, because rough litter textures aggravate sensitive paws and arthritic discomfort in senior cats.

- ❑ **Move the litter box to the same floor where your cat spends most of their time, eliminating any stairs between your cat and the box, because senior cats avoid boxes that require navigating painful or disorienting stairs.:** Move the litter box to the same floor where your cat spends most of their time, eliminating any stairs between your cat and the box, because senior cats avoid boxes that require navigating painful or disorienting stairs.

ADDRESS COGNITIVE AND ENVIRONMENTAL FACTORS

- ❑ **Set up a second box in a different location following the one-plus-one rule, because a senior cat with mobility limitations may be refusing the box simply because it is too far or hard to reach.:** Set up a second box in a different location following the one-plus-one rule, because a senior cat with mobility limitations may be refusing the box simply because it is too far or hard to reach.

- ❑ **Watch for cognitive decline signs including disorientation, changes in sleep-wake cycles, and eliminating right next to the box instead of inside it, because cognitive dysfunction syndrome is frequently underdiagnosed and directly causes litter box refusal.:** Watch for cognitive decline signs including disorientation, changes in sleep-wake cycles, and eliminating right next to the box instead of inside it, because cognitive dysfunction syndrome is frequently underdiagnosed and directly causes litter box refusal.

- ❑ **Document which surfaces and locations your cat uses versus avoids over a two-week period after making changes, because this tracking reveals patterns that help you fine-tune the setup for your specific cat's needs.:** Document which surfaces and locations your cat uses versus avoids over a two-week period after making changes, because this tracking reveals patterns that help you fine-tune the setup for your specific cat's needs.

- ❑ **Check the Full Guide:** This step is described in detail in the companion guide — open senior-cat-litter-box-refusal_v1.md and review the relevant section.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.